

5 Whys

Ask why of the answer, five times, until you reach a cause you can actually act on.

BEST FOR A PROBLEM · TOYOTA, 1950S · TAKES TEN MINUTES

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Write the problem as one observed fact.
Not "the band is flaky" but "we have missed four of the last six practices". Say how you know.
2. Ask why it happened. Write one answer, a cause you could check, not the same event in other words.
3. Ask why of that answer, not of the original problem. Write the next answer beneath it.
4. Keep going. Whenever the answer is a person's mistake, ask why the mistake was possible, or why it mattered.
5. Stop when you reach something you could change tomorrow. Five is a guide, not a rule. Three is often enough, and if the fifth still isn't something you can act on, the chain went sideways: start again from the first why.
6. Write the change as an action. Then check it backwards: if that had been in place, would the chain have broken?

Where it falls down. It assumes one chain of causes.

WITH A PEN

The problem, as an observed fact

What went wrong, and how do you know

Why did that happen?

Because... a cause, not the event in other words

And why did that happen?

Asked of the answer above

And why did that happen?

And why did that happen?

And why did that happen?

Can you act on this cause? Yes: root cause. No: redo from the first why

The fix that breaks the chain

Something you could change tomorrow